




AFRICAN LEADERSHIP DEVELOPMENT CENTRE

TMC221

Lecture **5**

Overcoming **Discouragement** & Sustaining **Personal Success**

w/ Azubuike **EZENWOKE, PhD**



What Is Discouragement?

The slow leak that drains your courage to continue

Discouragement is the gradual withdrawal of the courage to continue.

It shows up as:

- **Academic pressure** — poor grades, imposter syndrome
- **Social comparison** — watching peers "have it all together"
- **Financial constraints** limiting your options
- **Career uncertainty** — "What do I do with this degree?"
- **Failure** in relationships, goals, or extracurricular pursuits

The Real Enemy

It's not the problem — it's your response

"For a just man falleth seven times, and riseth up again." — Pro 24:16

The Wrong Response	The Right Response
Surrender to the pressure	Endure through the pressure
Define yourself by the fall	Rise every time you fall
Stop at the 49th blow	Deliver the 50th blow

Seven falls is not **Disgrace**. Staying on the floor is.



AFRICAN
LEADERSHIP
DEVELOPMENT
CENTRE

The Science of Grit

Angela Duckworth's landmark finding on achievement

Grit = Passion + Long-term Perseverance

What Predicts Success?

- ✗ IQ
- ✗ Talent
- ✗ Social class
- ✓ **Grit** — the only consistent predictor across all high achievers

Studied: West Point cadets, spelling bee champions, top entrepreneurs)

"Our potential is one thing. What we do with it is quite another."
— Angela Duckworth, *Grit*

The 50th Blow

Why the work you can't see is the most important work

The Sledgehammer

Principle: A man swings at a wall — blow after blow.

Nothing happens.

Blow 10 = Nothing.

Blow 30 = Nothing.

Blow 49 = Nothing.

Blow 50 = the wall collapses. — Dr Oyedepo

- It was not the **50th** blow that brought it down.
- It was the cumulative force of **ALL** the blows before it.
- The results you cannot see today are **being built by the work you are doing now.**
- Don't stop at blow 49.

You Are Not a Biological Accident

Vision is the anchor that holds you when storms come

Life without a God-ordained bearing is a burden. Life remains an endless struggle without vision. — **Dr. Oyedepo**

What Vision gives you:

- **Direction** — you know where you are going
- **Motivation** — you know *why* you are going there
- **Endurance** — you can withstand pain when the destination is worth it

"Where there is no vision, the people perish."
— Pro 29:18

What Is Vision?

Vision is a mission, not just a dream

Vision is a discovery of God's plan for one's life — a discovery of one's mission on earth." — **Dr. Oyedepo**

Two Definitions Side by Side

A Dream	A Vision
Vague and undefined	Specific and purposeful
About what you want	About what you are called to do
Fades under pressure	Anchors you under pressure
Self-centred	Need-meeting

Discover Your Vision

Three questions that unlock your purpose

Ask yourself honestly:

- **What problem breaks your heart?**
(The problem you are called to solve often reveals your purpose)
- **What could you do for free,** for life, and still feel fulfilled?
- **At age 70, looking back** — what would you regret not having done?

"If any man has no purpose for living, he is not fit to live." — Martin Luther King Jr.

The Three Pillars of Success

Vision + Information + Hard Work

"Success is a complex, multi-component product made up of several systems." — Dr. Oyedepo,

- **VISION** → Know where you are going
- **INFORMATION** → Feed your mind relentlessly
- **HARD WORK** → Perspiration is the price

Information without hard work ends in **Frustration**.

Hard work without vision ends in **Exhaustion**.

Vision without information ends in **Stagnation**.

Pillar 1 — Vision in Practice

Run with precision, not just passion

If you don't have a target, you'll keep following whatever is popular." — Dr. Oyedepo

The Precision Test — A goal must be:

- **Specific** — not "do better," but "achieve 4.90 GPA"
- **Measurable** — you can track it
- **Time-bound** — it has a deadline
- **Written** — if it is not written, it is a wish

Write your top 3 goals for the next 12 months. That is your target. Now run.

Pillar 2 — Information

Knowledge is the new currency of the world

One is either building a library or building a mortuary without knowing. — Dr. Oyedepo

The Reading Habit — The 1% Rule:

Action	Daily Time	Annual Output
Read non-academic books	20–30 min	12–18 books/year
Over 4 years of university	Daily	48–72 books

Biblical Models of Lifelong Learners:

- **Daniel** — remained relevant under 3 kings for 65 years
- **Paul the Apostle** — "Bring the books" (2 Tim. 4:13)

Pillar 3 — Hard Work

There is no shortcut — perspiration is the price

Until you're ready for the sweat, you're not set for the sweet." — **Dr. Oyedepo**

The Alexander Kroll Story:

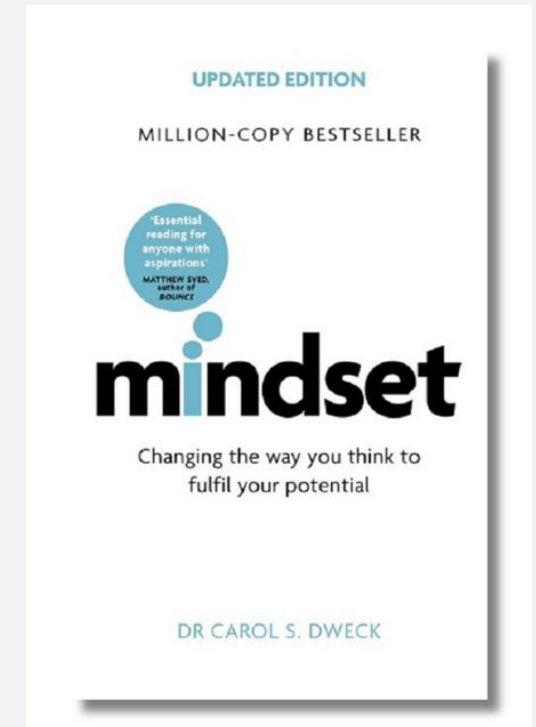
- **Dreamed** of being a footballer — Wrong physical build.
- **Solution:** Woke at **2:30 a.m. every night** to train.
- **Result:** Built the muscles. **Earned his place on the team.**



Fixed Mindset vs Growth Mindset

Carol Dweck

Fixed Mindset	Growth Mindset
"I'm just not smart enough"	"I haven't mastered this yet"
Failure = who I am	Failure = feedback
Avoids challenge	Embraces challenge



Every weight of glory is preceded by a season of **perspiration**.

Sustaining the Fire — Strategy #1

RESIST — Build endurance like a soldier (2 Tim 2:3)

Four Truths About Resistance:

- Discouragement attacks hardest in the **middle** of the journey
- Every champion has **marks of failure** in their past record
- **Opposition** is not a sign to stop — it is proof you are moving
- The crown is on the other side of the endurance
- "Winners never quit, and quitters never win."
— **Oral Robert**

Rise again. Every time.
That is the strategy.

Sustaining the Fire — Strategy #2

GUARD YOUR JOY — It is a weapon, not a luxury

Joy Stimulants

- **Daily gratitude** practice — write 3 things to God you are thankful for
- Forward-looking, purpose-driven peer group
- Regular service to others

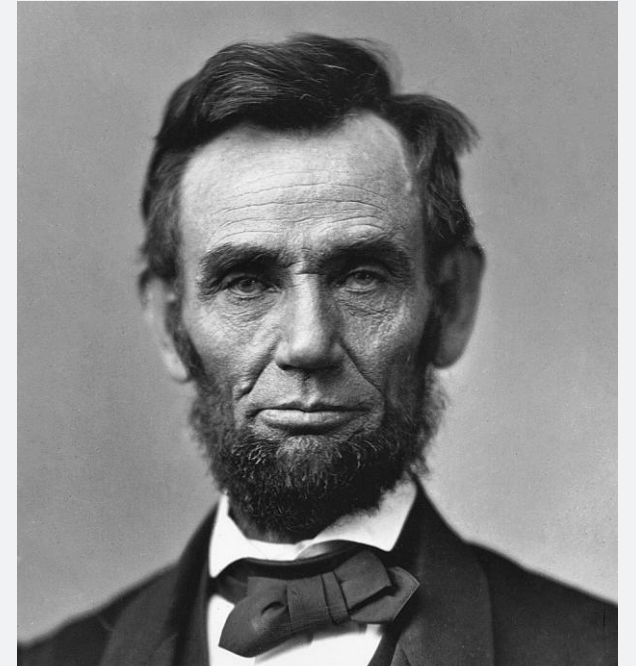
The longer your face, the longer your way. Only excited people are licensed to excel."
— Dr. Oyedepo

Sustaining the Fire — Strategy #3

PERSEVERE — Lincoln's greatest lesson

Ab Lincoln's Record Before the Presidency:

- Failed in business — twice
- Lost legislative races — multiple times
- Suffered personal tragedies
- Widely dismissed as a political failure
- **Elected 16th President of the United States**
— Became arguably the greatest president in American history.



Your setback is not
your final chapter.
Keep writing.

Sustaining the Fire — Strategy #4

SPEAK YOUR DREAM — A closed mouth is a closed future

Joseph's Principle:

- Told his dream → caused immediate trouble
- Trouble led to Egypt → Egypt led to the palace
- **The telling was the first step to the fulfilling**

Research-backed:

People who write goals and share with an accountability partner are **76% more likely to achieve them**
(Dr. Gail Matthews)

Your 7-Step Personal Success Plan

Every purpose not pursued is sure to die — Dr. Oyedepo

Step	Action
1. Purpose	Write your one-sentence mission
2. Planning	Map your 4-year milestones
3. Programming	Block time on your calendar
4. Pursuit	Begin today — not tomorrow
5. Appraisal	Review every semester honestly
6. Perseverance	Expect setbacks; plan through them
7. Receive	Do not stop until the crown is yours

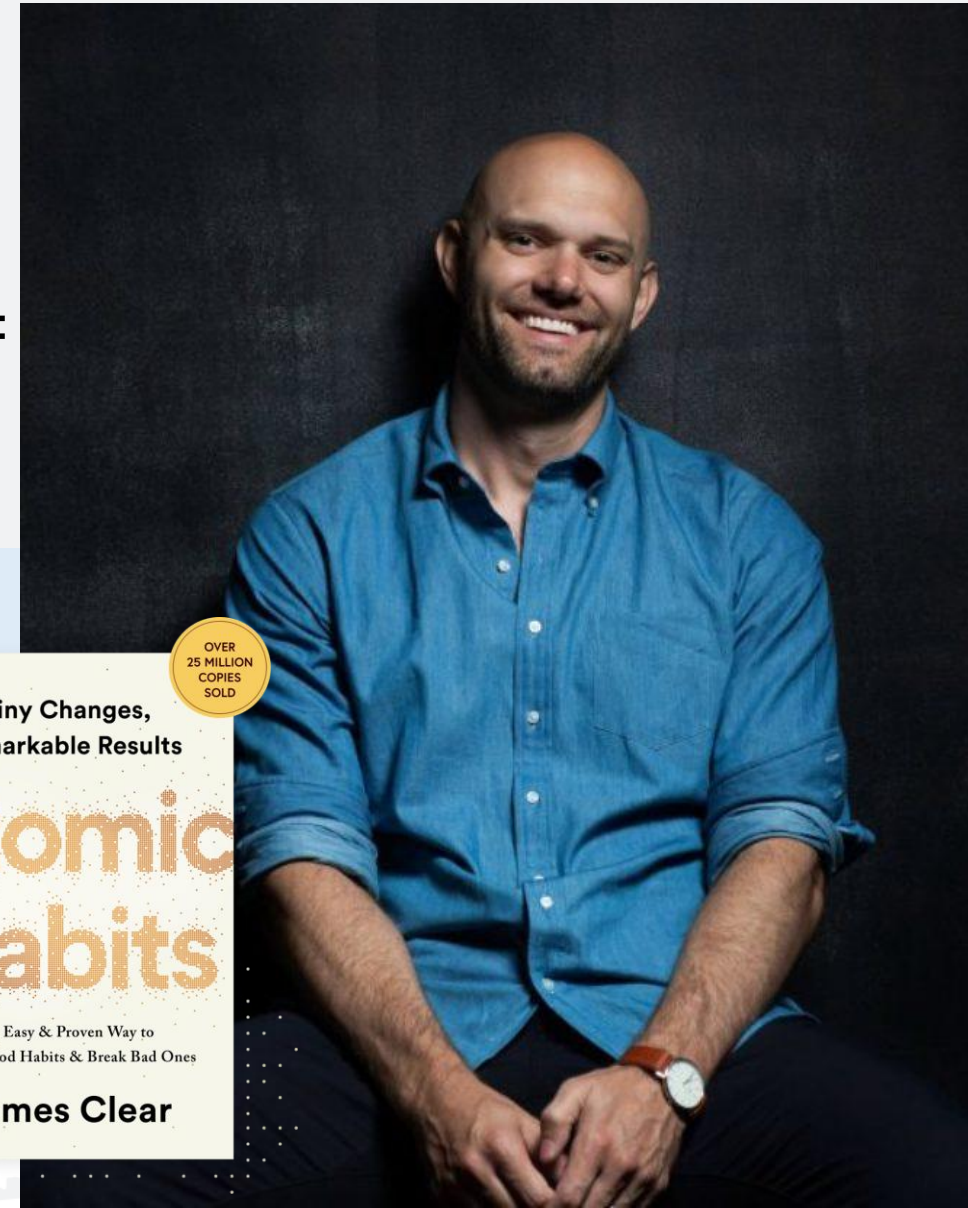
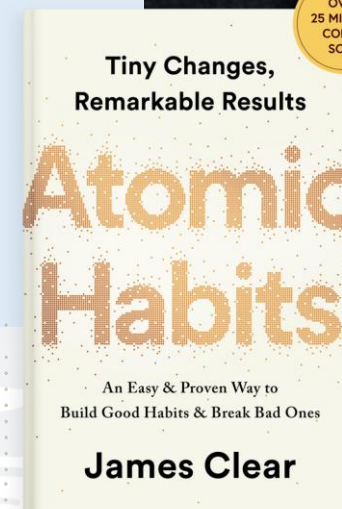
You do not rise to the level of your goals. You fall to the level of your systems." — **James Clear**

Conclusion

Small disciplines compounded daily =
Extraordinary Results

Atomic Habits shows us: *1%
better every day = **37x** better in a
year.

— James Clear



Thank You
Questions *and*
Comments

